

GE Reflection Paper

My career objective is to broaden my knowledge of the world and its cultural influences over time. I'm a History major and so I'm fascinated with the study of change in social norms, power structures and cultural identities and how these changes continue to shape the world we currently live in. I wish I can carry on with a profession that permits me to interface with various communities through instructing, research, cultural maintenance or open service in the long run.

The General Education program has given me a wide range of knowledge that helps me in my studies of History. As a result of critical thinking and academic writing classes, I've enhanced my critical reading skills and ability to build cogent arguments with primary sources and clearly communicate ideas. These are skills all historians need to have. Furthermore, GE coursework in the social sciences has helped me to be a more all-round scholar because of how society institutions function with the individuals in different community and period.

The content of this course is closely related to my major since cultural attitudes and social norms are explored as they relate to participation in sports from various points in history. The course, for instance, examined the exclusion of women from competitive athletics in the early 20th century as a result of the dominant attitudes of that time towards femininity, good health and gender roles. Grasping these exclusions is relevant to my own academic discipline, history for example, which can explore ways in which dominant ideologies restrict access and opportunity of marginalised groups. The debates surrounding Title IX also highlighted the role of legislation in changing the culture over time, which is one of the themes in history.

This course has impacted my view on diversity in a way. At first I thought diversity was about racial and ethnic identity but I'm seeing now that my understanding was limited. However, the

course did make me think differently and was a catalyst for me to consider gender equity as an important element of inclusion. During this learning, the participants learned about the struggles faced by female athletes to gain their recognition and treatment, often against resistance from their own communities and how it is possible to do this not only through their own personal courage but through systemic change. The presentations and conversations on transgendered athletes also gave me a good dose of "what is fair and what is inclusive" and the need to discuss the matter in a respectful way to solve the problems. I now realize that diversity is more than representation, it is actively removing barriers to participation, to being seen. This knowledge will benefit my future cultural awareness and historical empathy-based career in so many ways.